my courtship of Nimmi, and wrote furious letters to Kairon Sahib, denouncing me for my callous treatment of their daughter. Goaded by the onslaught of their letters, the chief minister called for me and demanded to know what was going on.

I then narrated the truth about what took place in Delhi, explaining that there was nothing untoward in my friendship with the girl; we would meet for the occasional cup of coffee, or just for a chat. That was all, and if he and her family didn't believe me they could check with the girl.

He then shot back, 'Your intimacy with Nirmal has become a public scandal. This is very bad.'

I humbly said to him, 'Sir, if you are displeased with me I will resign and leave Chandigarh. But first, I request you to give me a fair and patient hearing.' I then proceeded to tell him that I loved Nimmi and wanted to marry her.

He listened sympathetically, and said, 'If you want to marry Nirmal, go ahead at once. Otherwise stop meeting her.'

I was overjoyed that the chief minister had believed me and that he had given his consent to our marriage. But what I didn't expect, and what I should have, was how difficult it was to break the social conventions of those days. In the 1960s, inter-caste marriages were frowned upon, and my family vehemently declared that under no circumstances would they agree to their brother marrying a Hindu.

By now the news of our relationship had reached Nimmi's parents, and they were furious. Her father, Choudhury Mehar Chand Saini, was an influential man and staunch Arya Samaji, and he was convinced that if his daughter married a Sikh his reputation and izzat would be at stake. Besides, they had been trying to fix a match for her with an eligible engineer who had just returned from Canada. They demanded that Nimmi return home to Pathankot immediately and attempted to brainwash her to accept the proposal.

When Nimmi returned to Chandigarh, she was deeply distressed and wept in my arms. Would family pressure force us to part? Was this the end of our romantic dreams? Despite her sorrow, Nimmi found the courage to confront her mother with an ultimatum—either to allow her to marry Milkha Singh or she would remain a spinster all her life. But her threats made no difference to their opposition.